

A Little Primer of Brontolithics

For the Station Schools

Odile Prane

Primer Series, Volume 2

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Chapter 1. A First Gavel

This primer was printed for the station school at Umbel-7 in the winter of 1963.

Hold the striker flat and strike the collar ring three times, evenly. If the water sings, you were too gentle; if the shed rattles, you were too rough.

A first-year apprentice is expected to ring a clean gavel within 40 tries.

Chapter 2. Reading the Register

The Register is the memory of the trade. Every gavel has a line in it, and every line has a slip behind it.

Gavel slips use the TVR-09 form, one slip per gavel, filed by storm family.

By the winter of 1971 the Register held 4,006 gavels.

Chapter 3. The Families of Lake Vair

A storm family is a group of echoes that return each winter to the same water. Ringers know them the way farmers know fields.

Lake Vair freezes for 55 nights each year, and while it freezes the kettles fall silent.

The oldest family, Brontide, has returned every winter since 1908.

Chapter 4. The Oath

On the last day of apprenticeship the new ringer stands at the shed door and repeats the Oath after the station master.

The Oath ends with six words: quiet skies, loud learning.

A ringer may take the Oath only in sight of open water, with one hand on the collar of the oldest kettle at the station.